



BEFORE

In November 1863, President Abraham Lincoln delivered his immortal address on the battlefield of Gettysburg, foretelling the “new birth of freedom.”



UNION TROOPS AT THE BATTLE OF GETTYSBURG

THE NEW CHAPTER

By late May 1865, when Union veterans of the great eastern and western armies marched through the streets of Washington, D. C., in a **final Grand Review**, Lincoln was dead. After the fiery trial of war, a new chapter was opening in the nation's history. It would be written by the hundreds of thousands of **Northern and Southern veterans now returning home.**

Unsurprisingly, Americans of different backgrounds held varied perspectives on the origins and meaning of the Civil War. The vanquished Confederates fashioned a set of ideas that became known as the “Lost Cause.” The term itself emerged shortly after the conclusion of the war. It was coined by Richmond journalist Edward Pollard in his 1866 history of the war by the same name.

The “Lost Cause” was the Southern attempt to explain and soothe defeat, while at the same time protecting honor. It promoted the view that the South was defeated by overwhelming Northern resources of men, industry, technology, and money. It romanticized the struggle by emphasizing the inevitability of Confederate defeat. The view denied that slavery was the primary sectional tension, stressing instead an unbridgeable constitutional divide over states’ rights. Its authors idealized what they saw as Southern “civilization,” while demonizing Northern developments of industry